

A photograph of several children holding hands in a circle outdoors. In the center, a young girl with brown hair and blue eyes looks upwards. To her right, a boy in a striped shirt looks to the side. Other children's faces and arms are visible around the circle. The background is filled with green foliage and sunlight filtering through the trees.

CHILDHOOD THROUGH PUBERTY

NURS 280 JUNE 4, 2026



BIRTH TO AGE 2

- Spontaneous, reflexive sexual response
- Require healthy touch
- Do not initially distinguish between genital and nongenital body parts; nudity, self-exploration and self-pleasure are healthy, developmentally appropriate behaviours

Kids this age are learning:

- names for body parts and how people feel about them
- rules/beliefs about gender

Kids this age are developing:

- attachment to family/caregivers
- basic social skills



AGE 2 TO 5

- Keen interest in their own body, and how other people's bodies look

Kids this age are learning:

- how they joined their family
- the differences between genders
- their body belongs to them
- types of touch

Kids this age are developing:

- certainty about their gender identity
- an understanding of private & public and how that relates to their body



AGE 5 TO 8

- Physical exploration of bodies is common at this age
- Self-pleasuring can become more intentional
- Peer bonding can become more intense

Kids this age are learning:

- how babies are made
- there are different types of families/couples—more than just the ones they've been raised with
- their bodies are changing as they get older

Kids this age are developing:

- an understanding of attraction/romantic relationships



PUBERTY CHANGES

Hypothalamus

GnRH



Pituitary gland

LH, FSH



Gonads (testicles, ovaries)

Estrogen, progesterone, testosterone, sperm, eggs



Puberty changes



AGES 9 - 12

- Masturbation is pleasure-centred but highly influenced by any messaging received from peers/family/media, etc.
- Less grossed out by sexuality and more interested/curious/intrigued
- Attraction to others shifts from friendship to crushes

Kids this age are learning:

- their bodies are changing (and they're normal)
- their beliefs and values are their own
- how and why people are sexual
- complex skills to understand and decode the meaning behind behaviours

Kids this age are developing:

- skills needed to start/build/maintain/end relationships
- a sense of justice/understanding of their rights



PUBERTY CHANGES—ALL BODIES

Big feet

Growth spurts

Skin changes

Perspiration and odor

Body hair

Voice changes

Moodiness

Crushes



PUBERTY CHANGES—SOME BODIES

Testosterone:

broader shoulders

frequent erections

nocturnal emissions

Estrogen:

wider hips

breast development

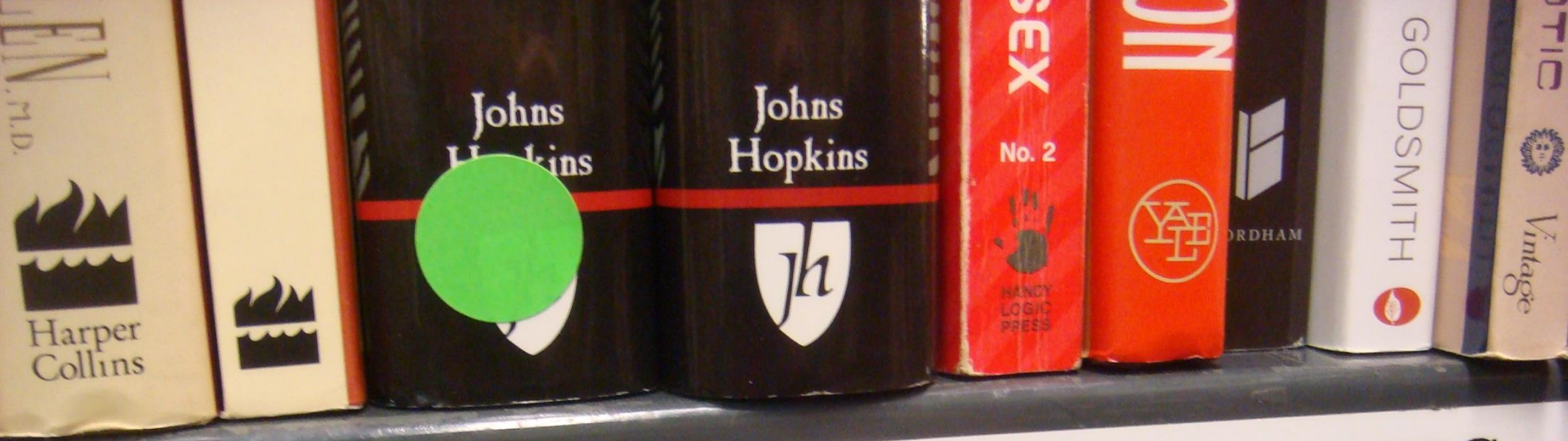
menstruation



PUBERTY CHANGES—KEY AREAS OF CONFLICT

- body changes → different treatment
- fluctuating hormones → moodiness
- lack of sleep → irritability
- increased interest in sex
- cognitive immaturity → poor decision-making
- poor emotion regulation
- increased desire for independent identity and self-expression:
 - experimentation
 - changing identities
 - changing values





SEXUALITY CONTINUES



THE UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA

